

🍳 Quantifiers & Food Cooking and Recipes

An A2 English Lesson — English For Comorians

Level: A2 (Elementary)

Topic: a lot of, a few, a little, too much / too many, not enough, plenty of

Characters: Ahmed, his mother, and his friend Yusuf

1. New Words (Vocabulary)

Countable food

TomatoesOnionsEggsPotatoesBananasApplesCarrotsPeppers

Uncountable food

RiceSugarSaltOilWaterFlourMilkMeatBread

Cooking verbs & kitchen words

CookChopBoilFryMixAddPeelTasteRecipeIngredientPotPanSpoonBowl

2. Grammar — Quantifiers

At A2 level, we use quantifiers to talk about amounts and quantities more precisely. Remember: **countable nouns** can be counted (one tomato, two tomatoes). **Uncountable nouns** cannot be counted directly (rice, water, sugar).

Quantifier	Countable / Uncountable	Meaning	Example
a lot of / lots of	Both	a large amount	We bought a lot of vegetables and lots of rice.
plenty of	Both	more than enough	Don't worry, there is plenty of food for everyone.
a few	Countable	a small number (positive)	I need a few eggs for this recipe.
a little	Uncountable	a small amount (positive)	Add a little salt to the soup.
few	Countable	almost none (negative)	There are few tomatoes left — we need more.
little	Uncountable	almost none (negative)	There is little oil left in the bottle.
too many	Countable	more than necessary (negative)	You added too many onions to the sauce.
too much	Uncountable	more than necessary (negative)	There is too much salt in this soup.
not enough	Both	less than necessary	There isn't enough water in the pot. We don't have enough potatoes.

A2 tip — "a few / few" and "a little / little":

A few and a little sound positive: "I have a few friends" (= some, that's good).

Few and little (without "a") sound negative: "I have few friends" (= almost none, that's a problem).

3. Dialog 1 — Planning Dinner

- Ahmed: Mom, what are we cooking for dinner tonight?
- Mother: I want to make vegetable soup, but I think we don't have enough carrots.
- Ahmed: Let me check... You're right, there are only a few carrots left.
- Mother: That's fine. We have plenty of potatoes and onions, so it will still be delicious.
- Ahmed: How much rice should I cook?
- Mother: Not too much — just a little, because we're only three people tonight.
- Ahmed: Should I go to the shop for more carrots?
- Mother: Yes, please. And buy a few tomatoes too, while you're there.

4. Dialog 2 — A Cooking Disaster

- Ahmed: Yusuf, I tried to cook rice by myself yesterday, but it was a disaster!
- Yusuf: Really? What happened?

Ahmed: Well, I used a lot of rice, but I didn't add enough water. The rice was hard.

Yusuf: That's a common mistake. Did you add salt?

Ahmed: Yes, but I think I added too much salt. It was really salty!

Yusuf: Ha ha! And the vegetables?

Ahmed: I chopped too many onions, so the taste was too strong.

Yusuf: Don't give up. Everyone makes mistakes when they learn to cook. Next time, use less salt and more water.

Ahmed: Thanks, Yusuf. I'll try again this weekend.

5. Reading Text — Cooking with My Mother

Every Sunday, I help my mother cook lunch for the whole family. She is an excellent cook, and she always has plenty of fresh ingredients in the kitchen.

This week, we decided to make a chicken and vegetable stew. First, my mother checked the fridge. "We have a lot of chicken and enough vegetables," she said, "but we don't have enough oil. Can you buy some from the shop?"

While I was at the shop, I also bought a few onions, a little ginger, and some fresh tomatoes. When I came back, my mother had already started chopping the carrots and potatoes.

"Don't add too much salt," she reminded me, as I always add a little too much. "A little salt is enough — we can always add more later, but we can't take it out!"

We cooked together for almost an hour. In the end, we had plenty of delicious stew for everyone, and there were even a few leftovers for the next day.

6. Recipe — Family Vegetable Stew

 **Family Vegetable Stew**

Ingredients: a lot of chicken, a few potatoes, a few carrots, a few tomatoes, a little ginger, a little oil, a little salt, plenty of water

Instructions:

1. Peel and chop a few potatoes and a few carrots.
2. Heat a little oil in a large pot.
3. Add the chicken and cook until it turns golden.
4. Add the chopped tomatoes and a little ginger. Mix well.
5. Add plenty of water so the stew doesn't dry out.
6. Add the potatoes and carrots, and a little salt — remember, not too much!
7. Let it boil for about 30 minutes, until the vegetables are soft.
8. Taste the stew. If it needs more salt, add a little more.

7. Exercises

Exercise A — Choose the correct quantifier

1. We have (a few / a little) apples in the fridge — maybe five or six.

2. There is (a few / a little) milk left in the bottle, not much.

3. I'm worried — we have (few / a few) eggs, only two! We need to buy more.

4. Don't add (too much / too many) sugar to the tea, it's already sweet.

5. There aren't (enough / plenty of) chairs for all the guests.

6. We have (plenty of / little) time before dinner, so let's relax.

Exercise B — Countable or Uncountable? Write C or U

1. Meat	_____	5. Peppers	_____
2. Bread	_____	6. Flour	_____
3. Carrots	_____	7. Bananas	_____
4. Oil	_____	8. Water	_____

Exercise C — Fill in with a suitable quantifier

- Use: a lot of, a few, a little, too much, too many, not enough, plenty of
1. Can you buy some onions? We only have _____ left — maybe one or two.

2. This soup is very salty. I think you added _____ salt.

3. Relax, we have _____ food for everyone at the party.

4. The stew needs more flavor. Add _____ pepper.

5. There are _____ chairs. Everyone can sit down. (positive, big number)

6. We can't make the cake — there isn't _____ flour.

Exercise D — Correct the mistakes

Each sentence has one mistake with a quantifier. Rewrite the sentence correctly.

1. There is too many salt in the soup. → _____
2. We have a little tomatoes for the salad. → _____
3. She added too much onions to the pan. → _____
4. I bought a few water at the shop. → _____

Exercise E — Reading comprehension (about Text 5)

1. What did the family decide to cook on Sunday?
2. Why did Ahmed go to the shop?
3. What did Ahmed buy at the shop?
4. Why does Ahmed's mother remind him about the salt?
5. What happened to the leftovers?

Exercise F — Write your own recipe

Write a short recipe for a dish from your country. Use at least 5 different quantifiers.

Name of the dish: _____

Ingredients: _____

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____
4. _____
5. _____

Exercise G — Speaking & discussion (with a partner)

1. Do you enjoy cooking? Why or why not?
2. Tell your partner about a time you made a cooking mistake.
3. What ingredients do you always have plenty of at home?
4. Is there any food you eat too much of? Is that healthy?
5. Describe how to cook your favorite dish, using quantifiers.

Answer Key

Exercise A: 1. a few 2. a little 3. few 4. too much 5. enough 6. plenty of

Exercise B: 1. U 2. U 3. C 4. U 5. C 6. U 7. C 8. U

Exercise C: 1. a few 2. too much 3. plenty of 4. a little 5. a lot of 6. enough

Exercise D:

1. There is too much salt in the soup.
2. We have a few tomatoes for the salad.
3. She added too many onions to the pan.
4. I bought a little water at the shop.

Exercise E:

1. Chicken and vegetable stew.
2. Because they didn't have enough oil.
3. A few onions, a little ginger, and some fresh tomatoes.
4. Because he always adds a little too much salt.
5. There were a few leftovers for the next day.

Exercise F & G: Free answers — check students' own sentences.